
Component 1: Personal Investigation

Overview

This component is weighted 60% of the total qualification.

This component incorporates **three major elements: supporting studies, practical work** and a personal study of a minimum 1000 words of continuous prose.

These elements should be seen as integrally connected. Supporting studies may combine investigation and research for both the practical work and personal study, however, the personal study **must** be presented as a separate outcome. The practical work and personal study may be approached in any order, or progress simultaneously.

The purpose of the Personal Investigation is to develop a portfolio of practical work and a minimum 1000 words of continuous prose that shows critical understanding in relation to the practical portfolio. This component offers teachers ample opportunities to structure programmes of study that encourage breadth and depth in the development of students' visual language.

Work produced will be based around themes and subject matter developed from personal starting points, to be negotiated with the teacher. The Personal Investigation is internally set and assessed, and externally moderated. Centres should support students in addressing the aims and objectives for the component. All work must be completed in advance of internal assessment and standardisation. The personal study must be submitted for assessment at the same time as the practical work.

This component is assessed against all four Assessment Objectives. Please see pages 33–35.

Supporting studies

Supporting studies can help to generate ideas and focus for the practical work and the written personal study. Supporting studies will be evidenced throughout the working process and can take many forms, such as recorded research, written annotation and practical exploration and development.

Supporting studies must be submitted with outcome(s) produced during the course of the Personal Investigation. Supporting studies must show the full breadth and depth of students' visual and written critical thinking in the progress of their work for both elements.

Practical work

This work will consist of a body of development work and outcome(s). See pages 11–26 for further details relating to each title.

The personal study

The personal study will consist of a critical and analytical written piece of a minimum 1000 words continuous prose, making links to the student's own practical investigations, supported by contextual research. The personal study comprises 12% of the final qualification and is marked out of 18. Through the personal study, students will demonstrate understanding of relevant social, cultural or historical contexts. Students will also express personal interpretations or conclusions, and use technical and specialist vocabulary.

The focus of the personal study can be any concept, movement, person, people, artefact(s), or other source of reference. However, it must be related to their own ideas, investigations and practical work.

Students will not be specifically penalised on the basis of the length of their written component and any difference from the indicative minimum word count of 1000 words. However, failure to meet the minimum word count may restrict students' ability to develop the required depth and breadth to access the full mark range.

The personal study can take any form but must:

- be presented as a separate piece in writing
- be a minimum 1000 words on the chosen subject
- be written in continuous prose
- be in a presentable format for assessment
- include a full bibliography, citing all references.

Students will need to consider:

- critical and analytical content
- expression of personal interpretations and conclusions
- contextual research and understanding
- links between research, analysis and own investigations
- use of specialist terminology and vocabulary
- clarity of expression and language
- appropriate structure and presentation.

The personal study must be the student's own work, forming an essential part of their independent investigations. Development of the personal study may be supported through presentations to the class, discussions and individual tutorials. Teachers can also help students to focus their ideas for the personal study by asking them to produce a proposal or an outline of their intentions.

Students may support their progress in writing the minimum 1000 words with visual examples of their own work and the work of others, sketchbook annotation, notes from visits, exploration of materials and the development of their own ideas.

Any references to others' writing should be acknowledged through a bibliography. Internet sources should be cited with a brief description of the source material.

The personal study is marked against all four Assessment Objectives. An additional criterion for the marking of the written communication is included in the assessment grid on page 35.

To summarise:

- supporting studies will help to prepare for both practical work and personal study
- the practical work and personal study may be approached in any order, or progress simultaneously
- the outcome for the personal study must form a separate presentation
- work must not be added to or altered once submitted for assessment
- this component will be assessed using the assessment grid on pages 33–35. Assessment Objectives 1 to 4 should be applied to the practical work and supporting studies; criterion 5 (which covers all four assessment objectives) should be applied to the minimum 1000–word continuous prose personal study only.